Northern Reach Turnabout

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/51272410.

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Mature

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra)

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by Altecfenix

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Chapter 1

The proximity alarm wailed on as Catra groaned in exasperation.

"Ugh, must be more of those Rebel idiots. Scorpia, take care of them." Catra said, almost shooing Scorpia away.

Scorpia nodded, looking forlorn as she walked away.

"Well, She-Ra, time to get you-" Catra stopped as she turned around to see the spot where Adora was moments ago empty, as her mouth opened and closed a few times.

'Shit'

Entrapta pointed off in the direction of the store room with her hair. "She went that way."

With a groan, Catra walked off frustrated, passing into the storage room. "Of course you just have to make this hard, Adora, don't you? Where are you?" She called into the room full of crates and supplies as she deadlocked the door behind her. "Not going anywhere now, I'll find you eventually." Catra said as she leapt up to a crate stacked higher than the others.

She took a moment to scan the room, and saw Adora dip behind one of the crates.

'Gotcha!'

Deftly jumping from crate to crate with ease, Catra soon found her prey, stumbling her way down the aisle of supplies. Catra waited for the right moment, and pounced on Adora.

The two tumbled a few times before they came to a stop; Catra pinning a giggling Adora down. Adora's laughter gave Catra pause, as she found herself lost in a familiarity bordering on nostalgia.

“Stay. Put.” Catra said to Adora, keeping her weight fully on the Princess. The giggling died down, and Adora opened her eyes to see the face of her best friend, staring right back at her. Her eyes went wide in awe, causing Catra’s heart to skip a beat.The two just sat there, staring at one another. Catra in surprise, her chest tight; Adora wearing a dopey face of admiration.

“Stop! Stop looking at me like that!” Catra yelled at Adora in frustration, shocking herself how Adora’s hard stare stripped away all that armor Catra had built up.

“You…you look like my best friend.” Adora said, as the corner of her eyes began to fill.

“Oh, do I now?” Catra scoffed, getting a nod in response from Adora.

“Uh huh. I…I think she hates me now though. Do you think she hates me?” Adora asked, clearly out of her mind.

Yet again, Catra was caught off guard, blinking a few times, taking a deep breath, releasing a sigh. She sits back on top of Adora, less of a restraint than moments prior.

“How should I know? What did you do?” Catra took the only chance she may have to understand why the girl she loved left her at the mercy of Shadow Weaver, never looking back.

Adora sniffles. “I…I left her…I didn’t want to…” her eyes closed in a hard squint. “S-she wouldn’t come with me…she…why didn’t she come with me?” Her eyes opened once more. Steely blue eyes, filled with sadness, staring deep into Catra’s.

Catra’s eye began to sting hearing those words, feeling the frustration of the reversal.

“Because you left me! Years of watching Shadow Weaver torture me! Then you see one village razed, and now the Horde is evil? Was my life so insignificant to you that you would leave me to deal with your defection?!” Catra screamed at Adora, baring her

fangs, tears falling onto the woman below her. “Princesses? You left me for Princesses?! What do you expect, me to still lo-” Catra stopped herself, having, yet again, lost control.

Adora’s eyes went wide once more, tears flowing down the sides of her face. “C-Catra? Catra!” Adora yelled, throwing her arms around the smaller woman sitting atop her legs.

“Catra, I’m so sorry. I'm so sorry.” Adora said, full on sobbing now.

Catra abruptly shoved Adora off her, slamming her back down onto the ground with an ‘oof’ before standing up.

“You’re sorry?! Keep your empty apologies to yourself, you never cared about me!” Catra yelled once more.

She could see Adora’s face fall further into dismay. She was breaking Adora’s heart all over again, as Adora was breaking Catras.

Adora scooted back from Catra until her back was against a crate. She brought her knees up to her chest and began to wail. Between sobs, Adora repeated two phrases, over, and over.

“You do hate me”

“I’m so sorry”

Catra fell to the ground, watching Adora unravel. Her mind racing at the situation she’s been put in. Did she really hate Adora?

She knew the answer. She could never truly hate Adora.

Catra crawled over to the sobbing girl, sitting next to her until the sobs died down. The two of them sat there, each sniffling now and then.

“I don’t hate you, dummy.” Catra finally got out, throat tight and uncomfortable. “I could never hate you. You left me. You hurt me. So, SO much. I don’t know if I can ever forgive you.”

The hicks from the girl beside her began once more, her body shaking, no longer having the energy to sob as she had earlier as her face was buried in her knees.

Catra's chest hurt, hearing the misery from the girl she loved, or once loved. She still wasn't sure. Though seeing Adora like this was far more painful than she imagined. The words and feelings she had pent up had finally been expressed. She felt no relief, no satisfaction. Just more pain.

Catra wiped her face as she groaned. "I should have gone out there and let Scorpia babysit you." She said as she stood up. To her surprise, she felt Adora's hand clasp around her own.

She looked down at Adora in surprise, the blonde's face still hidden.

"P..Please…Stay?" Came the soft request, before those beautiful blue eyes, red and puffy, looked into Catra's own, right down to her soul. The desperation in her voice cut deep into what was left of Catra's resolve.

"Please?" Adora said once more, voice strained.

After a few moments, Catra sat back down next to Adora, their hands still clasped. No sooner did Catra's butt hit the ground, was Adora's head on her shoulder.

"I miss you." Adora said, matter of factly. Seemingly the first lucid thing Catra heard from her, though well aware the corruption still had Adora in its grasp. "I don't wanna miss you anymore."

Catra scoffed. "Should have thought of that before you threw in with princesses." She felt Adora's head shake in response.

"I never…I wanted you to come with me!" Adora said, Catra rolling her eyes in response.

Adora looked up at her friend. "You'd like them. Like, really like them. They're nice, really nice."

Another scoff from Catra. “Who, Sparkles and Arrow Boy? Sure, bet they are. Much better than me.”

Adora gasped. “No! No! You’re! You’re the best! You’re the sweetest most cutest person, I don’t care how mean you try to be! You’re my best friend! No matter what!”

Catra looked into Adora’s eyes once more, not an ounce of deception behind them.

“Catra please…please come home with me…it’s…it’s never been home, not without you!”

“You…you want me to what? Come to Brightmoon with you? Yeah, no thanks. I have no desire to be hanged.” She almost joked, trying to dismiss the notion.

“I wouldn’t let that happen! Please, Catra? I…I want to be home again.”

Catra closed her eyes, taking a breath to try and keep her mind from losing grip.

“You’re fucked up Adora. Your home is with those two. In Bright Moon. Not with me. You’ll regret this conversation as soon as you’re back to normal or whatever.” Catra said as she stood up, Adora losing the warm support she had been leaning on, hardly catching herself before she hit the ground.
She sat there, watching Catra walk away from her. Her stupor was strong, overwhelming, though was losing to something else.

“Why…” Came a small voice from behind Catra, turning around as her heart ached. Adora pulled her knees back into her chest.

“Why what?” Catra asked, her chest pained.

“Why don’t you want to be happy? I never see you happy anymore…that’s…that’s all I want. Why don’t you?”

The feeling in Catra’s chest erupted, as she growled.

“I was happy!” She yelled, taking a step toward Adora. “Then you found that stupid fucking sword, and those idiots took that away from me! It didn’t matter what happened, I had you. I was happy!” The rage quickly turning into despair, as Catra collapsed to her knees in front of Adora, tears falling down her cheeks. “I hate fighting you. I hate that you’re gone. I hate that you’re just going to forget this when you’re yourself again.” She said, her voice thick with the agony of love lost. “I hate…so much…” her voice was small, as the pain came out in sobs as she hid her face trying to stop the tears.

Catra soon felt warmth surrounding her, Adora had crawled to her, and enveloped Catra in her arms. Catra struggled against the embrace, though the more she struggled, the more the addled woman held tight.

“Let go of me! Stop it!” Her claws cutting into Adora, desperately trying to escape the torrent of pain and loss she felt, not wanting to let herself hope this was real.

The blonde wasn’t budging. Minutes of struggling, yelling, and slicing at Adora’s arms yielded to exhaustion, as Catra went limp in Adora’s arms.

She was in Adora’s arms. The one place she knew was home. The place she thought she would never return to. She heard a small giggle from Adora, and realized there was the smallest involuntary purr coming from her chest. Catra wordlessly ceased the action.

“Aww…I love your purr though…”

Catra scoffed.

“You’re an idiot.” only feeling a nod in response.

The two sat there, the soft purr returning, drinking in one another. Catra’s mind was racing, a battle raging in her mind.

“Don’t go back to the Fright Zone…I’ll do anything.” The surprisingly sober sounding voice of Adora cut through the

turmoil, a guiding light back to the moment.

Catra didn't make a sound. Didn't move a muscle. Her silent contemplation would have driven Adora mad if not for the state she was in.

Catra knew what she really wanted, and that little bit of hope shown through like a pin prick of light in the darkness.

A part of her grasped at that light with all the might she could, until she reached into her pocket, revealing the disc, using all of her strength to smash it against the floor.

Pieces of the disc scattered across the ground, as she felt Adora go limp for a moment before regaining her composure.

Adora rubbed her teary red eyes. "Wha…Catra?" Her memories since she was infected were a fog, but some of the more recent moments she had to grasp at as if it were a dream.

"Did you mean it? Do you even remember?" Catra asked, the fear in her voice apparent.

Adora looked at her, puzzled frustration painted across her face. "I'm sorry, Catra. I'm having a hard time remembering."

"Tch, of course." Catra said as she turned on her heel towards the door.

"Catra, wait!" Adora called as she grabbed Catra's arm gently. She winced as she felt the pain of the slices Catra had given her. Catra stopped, though kept her face turned away.

"It…it's like I was dreaming. You were here, and…and I told you I wanted you to come home with me. Is that what happened?" A curt nod was the only response Adora got.

Adora's eyes went wide, it hadn't been a dream.

"I…do mean it, Catra. Please, come with me." Adora pleaded.

Catra turned around, ripping her arm from Adora's hand, baring her teeth, and hissed at Adora, the pain she felt twisting her face.

"You left me! One little town gets attacked, and that's all it took for you to leave me! Do you even know what I had to go through? What you leaving did to me? Why would I ever go anywhere with you?!" She yelled through tears, taking steps toward Adora, forcing the blonde back into a wall. "I trusted you. Trusted only you!"

"Then why didn't you come with me?!" Adora yelled back. "I never wanted to leave with out you! I asked you to come, but no. You decided to stay with the Horde. You zapped me!"

"Because I wanted you to stay! I didn't care if I had to drag you back! Then those two just came right back and took you from me!"

The two yelled through their tears at one another.

"What happened to 'the two of us look out for each other'? That 'Nothing bad as long as we're together'?" Catra asked, her voice raspy from the yelling and emotional toll this all had taken.

Adora slid down the wall to a sitting position, exhausted. "I never wanted to break that, Catra. I never…never even imagined we could be enemies, but…here we are." She looked up at Catra. "I don't want to be enemies anymore. I can't go back, but I don't want to leave you. Not again." She shook her head. "Never, again."

Catra almost collapsed as she sat across from Adora. "You should have let me come with you. You should never have gone alone that night. I…I never wanted to be enemies either, Adora."

"Then come with me now!" She said as she leaned forward gently, setting her hand on Catra's knee.

Catra scoffed. "What does that look like to you, Adora? I just attacked Bright Moon. The whole Kidnapped Sparkles and let

Shadow Weaver torture her to get you back. Do you really see me living more than a day before I find a blade in my chest? Or back? Even you can't keep that from happening."

Adora shook her head. "That's not what would happen, Catra. I promise it won't. I don't care what you've done…come with me. I just…" she stopped as her voice broke.

"I…I love you, Catra."

Catra's eyes went wide, her ears alert, tail thrashing. "What…did you just say?"

"I love you!" Adora yelled. "I'm tired of fighting you…every time we fight, my heart hurts. I know…you don't feel the same…but-"

"You're wrong." Catra interrupted her.

"W-what?" Adora stammered trying to figure out what Catra meant.

"I do. I feel the same." She corrected, looking deep into Adora's eyes, saying the words that danced in her mind for as long as she knew. "I love you, Adora."

"You…do?!" Adora asked indignantly.

"Yes you idiot! I…always have. Ever since we were kids." Catra admitted. "If I knew you felt the same…" Catra lamented before she shook her head clear of the thought.

Adora sat still, speechless at the revelation.

"What…what do we do now?" Adora eventually asked.

Catra shrugged in response. "No idea. I planned on bringing you back with me…but now?" She sighed again then looked pleasingly at Adora. "I'm tired, Adora."

Adora smiled softly. "Then let me take you home. You can rest as much as you'd like." She said as she took Catra's hand in hers. "Then when you're ready, we can do whatever it is we need to do."

Catra scoffed again. "And how do we get out of here? I don't think Scorpia will be too happy about me defecting, and your friends want to kill me. Entrapta will be distracted with tech, so that's easy."

“Catra, Glimmer and Bow don’t want to kill you.” Adora said matter of factly.

“Kidnapped, tortured, battle?” She said with a bit of sass. “If they don’t want me dead they’re dumber than they look.”

“Okay, I get why you would think that, but even so; I will not let them hurt you. I won’t let anyone hurt you.” Adora said with authority as her eye’s glowed blue. The tone and sudden blue glow caused Catra’s mind to pause, consider, and accept Adora’s words with a nod.

“Okay. I believe you, Adora.” Catra said, allowing herself to be vulnerable for the first time since Adora left the Horde.

Adora nodded with a smile. “Good. Let’s get out of here.” she said as she stood up, pulling Catra to her feet along with her.

Departure

Chapter Notes

Surprise!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The unlikely group made their way back to *The Dragon's Daughter V* , the long cold walk made Catra shiver, finding what warmth she could by keeping close to Adora.

Her mind was racing, though her outward demeanor gave little away. The unknown of the future made her anxiety spike. All she could do was trust that Adora was able to keep her word. As hard as that was to accept for her after all that had happened, she couldn't trust anyone else.

She knew, in some part, that Entrapta and Scorpia wouldn't bring her any harm, though her mind would only let her trust Adora. The revelation they shared with one another earlier in the day had cemented that Catra could give up to Adora, and allow herself to tumble through the uncertainty of the coming days knowing that she had the only thing she truly wanted.

Adora.

The small peace that gave her was enough, as the smallest of smiles began to pull at her lips, leaning into Adora.

"You okay?" Adora asked as she felt Catra's weight.

Catra took a moment, breathing out heavily. "No…-Yes…I don't know. I'm just so cold."

Adora swung her arm around Catra, a small eep coming from the feline.

“I’m sorry, but we’ll be there soon, actually, that’s it right there!” Adora pointed as just over the horizon the mast of the boat could be seen.

Scorpia looked on at Catra and Adora. She knew this was the right decision, but could see why it came to pass. She would have to swallow her feelings for Catra.

Scorpia trudged along, carrying what she could of the important supplies that Entrapta had insisted they bring along, while the tech princess spent the walk recording notes she deemed important. They didn’t want any sign of where they went, and the tracking tech on any Horde transports would lead Hordak right to them, as much as they all wished they could have used one.

Glimmer and Bow walked silently through the snow, just behind Sea Hawk, a scowl painted across Glimmer’s face. She wanted that conversation with Adora.

She wanted answers.

Catra had done so much damage, Glimmer just couldn’t believe that Adora would just welcome her. It didn’t make sense, their history being considered or not.

She felt Bow bump into her slightly.

“It’ll be okay, Glimmer. Adora knows what she’s doing.” His delivery was honest, though not as reassuring as he aimed for.

“Does she?” Glimmer asked quietly. “We are bringing Catra, *Catra,* to Bright Moon with us. Not as a prisoner, or a corpse, but as a guest! I want to trust her, Bow, but I can’t help but think this is a terrible idea.”

Bow sighed. “And now you sound like your mom.”

Glimer shot him a mean look. “Yeah? Well she’d be right! I wouldn’t be surprised if she killed Catra herself.”

Catra could hear everything. The possibility of her death, once she was ambivalent towards, scared her. She didn't want to leave now that she had her Adora.

They all made their way up the gangplank of the boat, Adora bringing Catra below deck almost immediately. It was a small vessel, but the hold was perfect for keeping the freezing woman out of the cold.

Adora closed the hatch behind them, turned around, and hugged Catra.

It took a moment, but Catra returned the embrace, gradually hugging tighter and tighter as Adora's warmth permeated Catra's chill, though her shiver remained.

"They're going to kill me, Adora." She said, shakily.

Adora shook her head. "No, Catra. I'm not going to let that happen. Angella will see sense, and…well, she will understand. You'll be safe." She broke the embrace, and set her forehead to Catra's.

"I promise."

WIth those words, she grabbed a cargo blanket, and wrapped it around Catra.

"I'm going to go above. Stay here and keep warm, okay? I'll be back soon."

Seeing a nod from Catra as she snuggled up into the blanket, Adora left Catra to herself.

"You know, now that you mention it, it was really strange that I hadn't ever seen you before." Scorpia said to Sea Hawk as Adora closed the hatch behind her.

"I was surprised I was able to fool you! Though I am a cunning man, do not blame yourself!"

Glimmer walked up to Adora, arms crossed. “Well?”

Her tone surprised Adora, reminding her of the day the two met.

“Okay, I know…I know this may sound crazy but…” Adora sighed. “I love her, Glimmer…”

Glimmer’s eyes went wide. “You *what?!* ” She asked, gritting her teeth. “Adora, how could you love her? All the terrible things she has done, and you just up and fall in love with her?”

Adora walked to the bow of the ship, away from the others, Glimmer close behind.

“It’s not like that, Glimmer. I think I always have. Remember when I was infected before, at Dryl?”

“Yeah?”

“Well, when I was…infected, Catra and I talked. It’s…a blur, but I do remember. She destroyed the disc, Glimmer. I…didn’t know but…she...loves me too.” Adora said, blushing, unable to keep the smile off her lips.

Glimmer’s hand came up to meet her face. ‘Okay, so you two are in love. Great. Just great.”

Adora’s face fell as her mind kept running.

“It’s my fault, Glimmer. I should have never left without her at Thaymore. So much could have been avoided if I had just…” Adora hugged herself as regrets of the past washed over her, her eyes bolted shut. “If only I brought her that night.”

Glimmer sighed as she closed the gap, and hugged Adora.

“I hope you know what you’re doing, Adora. You’re explaining this to my mom, though.”

Glimmer felt Adora nod. She felt a little better about the situation, though only time would tell if this was a good idea.

Chapter End Notes

A shorter chapter, though I think as I continue this work, they will remain short. JBTS is the main fic I spend my time on, but I do love these other projects!

End Notes

Thanks for reading!

This is a part of a writing prompt challenge that the Just Below the Surface Discord server did!

This will be a part of a collection with the other shorts.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!